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Rajasthan C-sec deaths: Centre seeks report after WHO asks for info

Anonna Dutt
& Parul Kulshrestha
New Delhi, Jaipur, June 26

THE UNION Health Ministry has asked the Rajasthan government for a detailed report on women developing complications following caesarean operations across several government hospitals in the state, with some resulting in casualties.

Sources said the ministry sent a note after the World Health Organization (WHO) sought information from the Indian government on the possible link of spurious oxytocin to the cases. The WHO sought information to ascertain whether the issue was localised, or more widespread, with potential risk at other locations, the source said.

The Centre action followed

E. EXPLAINED

Drug under spotlight

Oxytocin is used to induce labour before a delivery and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after it. Many of the women who died or developed complications in Rajasthan saw excessive blood loss.

after the Rajasthan government and the top drug regulator in the country cancelled licences of a Kota-based wholesale drug distributor of oxytocin and two factories manufacturing the drug in Punjab and

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Telegram key platform for drug ads, Myanmar route a concern: NCB

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, June 26

ENCRYPTED MESSAGING platforms such as Telegram, WhatsApp and Signal have become major channels for drug trafficking worldwide, including in India. Of these three, Telegram has emerged as a key platform for drug-related advertising, according to the Narcotics Control Bureau's Annual Report 2025 released Friday.

According to the report, released by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Telegram has become a prominent drug advertising platform, with public channels offering product list-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the Apex-Level Meeting of the Narco-Coordination Centre in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

ings, pricing and delivery details to large subscriber bases.

“Unlike darknet markets,

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

NCB

which require specialised access, these platforms are widely accessible via smartphones, lowering entry barriers and enabling broader reach... Enforcement on these platforms is challenging because of jurisdictional issues in securing platform cooperation, the ephemeral nature of content, including auto-deletion of messages, and the use of multiple accounts, layered communication methods, and cryptocurrency payments by vendors to maintain anonymity," the report said.

Earlier this month, the

Centre temporarily restricted Telegram in India ahead of the June 21 NEET-UG retest on the grounds that it was being used by "cheating rackets". While access to the app was restricted until June 22, its message-editing feature was disabled until June 30.

The report by the apex drug law enforcement agency also flagged a trafficking corridor from Myanmar into India's Northeast as a major security concern, warning that the drug trade in the region is linked to arms smuggling and financing of terror groups.

"Myanmar has now overtaken Afghanistan as the leading source of illicit opium," the report said, "with the change

driven by the after-effects of the Taliban's ban on poppy cultivation and the continued expansion of cultivation in Myanmar amid conflict and economic breakdown."

"The porous border (between India and Myanmar) and Free Movement Regime facilitate trafficking, exacerbate local addiction, and fund insurgent groups," the report said.

The report also pointed out that India is facing mounting pressure from a rapidly changing global narcotics landscape, marked by the rise of ultra-potent synthetic opioids and a record cocaine output.

The report flagged two emerging threats that require urgent attention: the spread of

nitazenes, a class of synthetic opioids said to be 500 times more potent than heroin, and the increasing link between drug trafficking and organised violence across transit economies.

"Drug law enforcement agencies across the country registered an all-time high of over 1.48 lakh cases and effected seizures of more than 1,200 tonnes of narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances. The scale and diversity of seizures, ranging from plant-based drugs to synthetic substances, pharmaceutical diversions and precursor chemicals, underscore the evolving and complex nature of the threat," NCB Director Anurag Garg said in the report.

C-section deaths

Himachal, respectively. Sources said inspections had discovered widespread irregularities, including the absence of evidence of key tests regarding drug purity and proof of data fudging.

Oxytocin is used to induce labour before a delivery and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after it. Many of the women who died or developed complications in Rajasthan saw excessive blood loss.

In the latest case, eight women who underwent C-sections at the District Government Hospital in Paota, Jodhpur, on June 20 fell ill after surgery. Two of them who developed complications were moved to AIIMS, Jodhpur, and all are stable now.

Before that, complications were reported after caesarean deliveries at PBM Hospital in Bikaner. Of the six women who developed kidney failure after surgery, two died. The Bikaner cases followed a more severe episode in Kota, where five women died in May after undergoing caesarean deliveries at the New Medical Government Hospital. More than 40 days later, five other women remain admitted and continue to require dialysis after suffering kidney failure.

The Rajasthan authorities have denied a link between the deaths.

On the WHO approaching the Central government, an official said: "It is a routine part of the global pharmacovigilance and regulatory surveillance mechanism. The organisation regularly seeks information... to determine whether such incidents are confined to a particular location or whether there could be any implications for other countries... It should not be construed as a finding against the product or the manufacturer."

The findings

CENTRE: In the first week of June, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) held a joint inspection of the manufacturing units in Punjab and Himachal of Jackson Laboratories, the manufacturer of the oxytocin that is under a cloud in Rajasthan, along with the regulators of the two states.

Following the inspection, the licences of the units were cancelled.

Sources said that the inspection found that Jackson Laboratories, which has earlier too faced action over its products, was found to have not complied with a 2023 order by state regulators directing it to stop the production of several tablets, capsules, and injectables, on grounds of its unhygienic conditions.

Sources said a state drug regulator has now ordered Jackson to recall all the medicines it produced after the 2023 order, as well as to recall other drugs it failed in quality control tests. Sources said the company violates several good manufacturing requirements, including separate spaces for various processes.

As per officials, evidence of "record tampering" was also found in the specific batches of oxytocin supplied to Rajasthan. This includes the date of the sample being received by a quality control lab being different on the test report and the lab intake. There is reportedly no record of testing having been done on a key aspect for a drug's purity, as well as alleged evidence of data files on the testing equipment being modified or deleted.

Sources said the drug inspectors also found that raw data for the tests to check for impurity could not be provided by the company, neither did it reportedly have raw data on testing of the active pharmaceutical ingredient, which is mandated.

The inspecting teams reportedly also found that finished oxytocin was stored at around 27 degrees C instead of the recommended 2 to 8 degrees C.

RAJASTHAN: On Tuesday, the Rajasthan Drug Control Department cancelled the wholesale drug licence of Kota-based pharma distributor Rajasthan

Medical Hall, over the alleged sale of thousands of spurious oxytocin injections and other irregularities.

As per an order issued by Rajasthan Drug Licensing Officer and Assistant Drug Controller Devendra Kumar Garg, officials on May 19 inspected Rajasthan Medical Hall, and discovered irregularities, including that the firm did not maintain a mandatory inspection register and had no qualified pharmacist on site.

Authorities said they also found that, while the firm purchased 9,300 units of Tocin 1 ml injection manufactured by Jackson Laboratories, it sold 10,050 injections from the same batch. The Rajasthan Drug Testing Laboratory later declared the batch spurious, saying tests revealed that the injections contained no trace of oxytocin, its active ingredient.

The Rajasthan Drug Controller order said that, in response to a show-cause notice over the discrepancy in injections procured and sold, Rajasthan Medical Hall produced a letter from Jackson Laboratories claiming that 750 additional injections had been dispatched separately by bus. However, the Drug Control Department found the explanation unsatisfactory.

"Further examination of the matter is underway, and additional action will be taken in accordance with the findings," the Union Health Ministry source said.

What caused Rajasthan maternal deaths? Not just spurious oxytocin, say Govt doctors

Anonna Dutt
New Delhi, June 26

WHILE THE focus in the maternal C-section deaths in Rajasthan's Kota, Bikaner and Jodhpur towns has been on the use of substandard oxytocin --- which minimises blood loss and prevents postpartum hemorrhage (PPH) --- administered to them, experts say that deaths more likely happened because of birth-related complications.

The Union Health Ministry has stayed away from investigation into the maternal deaths in Rajasthan, saying it is a state issue and that it had not sent any team from the All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS). But local officials, on condition of anonymity, say, "The maternal deaths have been linked to the use of substandard oxytocin that did not contain the active ingredient. We are yet to receive any word on the deaths in Jodhpur."

Oxytocin is a medicine that can be used to induce labour before a delivery and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after it. Yet, gynaecologists say, had the oxytocin not worked, the doctors would have noticed the continued bleeding immediately, and used other methods to prevent further blood loss. "And, it is not that oxytocin is always

needed, many deliveries happen without it. The human physiology is such that the uterus contracts even on its own," says Dr Maruti Sinha, former head of gynaecology at one of Delhi's biggest maternity hospitals, Kasturba Hospital. "Assuming the drugs were spurious and the doctors would have noticed and managed them, there could have been other factors at play," she adds.

Dr Nutan Agarwal, former professor at the All-India Institute of Medical Sciences (AIIMS), says hypertension during pregnancy (commonly known as preeclampsia) is another common cause for such organ failure.

"Women need regular check-up throughout their pregnancy to monitor whether they have high blood pressure (BP). Such pregnancies are high risk and have to be handled well. The change in their condition can be sudden --- they can be normal one minute and their BP might shoot up the next. If you do not deliver on time in such a case, it can lead to heart failure and failure of other organs, such as the kidneys." High BP during a C-section damages the kidneys by reducing blood flow and causing severe inflammation. These stressors can lead to Acute Kidney Injury (AKI) through restricted blood vessels, oxygen

“Acute kidney failure is usually caused by either haemorrhage before or after the delivery, preeclampsia or hypertension during pregnancy, and sepsis. These can be managed if the patient reaches a hospital on time. But in most cases they arrive very late...”

DR ANJALI DABRAL, RETIRED GYNAECOLOGIST FROM DELHI'S SAFDARIJUNG HOSPITAL

starvation, and heavy blood loss.

Dr Sinha says while she did not know the history of each patient, the deaths likely happened because of excessive bleeding, which can happen if C-section is not performed properly.

"With the rise in the number of C-section deliveries, there has been a corresponding increase in placenta accreta --- a condition where the placenta attaches too deeply to the uterine wall and does not come out easily after delivery. A skilled surgeon is needed to take the placenta out properly. Otherwise, it can lead to massive bleeding. Sometimes doctors have to perform hysterectomy (removal of uterus) even in women who have only had one child to save them from bleeding out," she says.

Bleeding before the pregnant woman reaches a hospital can also be a big risk factor. "If

they have already lost a lot of blood and there is another 500 ml to 800 ml loss during the C-section, new mothers can go into a shock." The sudden blood loss and circulatory shock can, in turn, result in organs such as kidney shutting down.

Aside from surgical complications, the most common reasons why women might end up losing excessive blood, and end up in circulatory shock, are haemorrhage and hypertension. Women can end up with kidney damage and multi-organ failure because of sepsis (blood infection), as was seen in the cases of maternal deaths in Rajasthan as well. "Acute kidney failure is usually caused by either haemorrhage before or after the delivery, preeclampsia or hypertension during pregnancy, and sepsis. These can be managed if the patient reaches a hospital with adequate infrastructure on time. But in most

cases they arrive very late, often after bleeding for a long duration, so by the time they reach the hospital, their organs start shutting down," says Dr Anjali Dabral, retired gynaecologist from Safdarjung hospital, Delhi's other high volume maternity centre.

She adds that kidney failure can also happen if the woman has pre-existing chronic kidney disease. Dr Sheeba Marwah, associate professor at Safdarjung Hospital, says, "Sepsis may occur because good hygiene practices were not followed during the C-section, but they are more likely because of prolonged leaking of the amniotic fluid, multiple checks during a long labour and ungloved checks. The risk also goes up when a woman is anaemic --- and 80% of pregnant women who come to us are. Anaemia limits the body's ability to carry oxygen properly --- and in its absence the body cannot fight off infections well."

Dr Agarwal adds that there is a need to ensure that women receive regular ante-natal checkups, get their C-section done by qualified doctors and the hospital have a proper transfer facility in case a woman needs to be moved to a higher centre because of an emergency. "While the trend is changing, many still come to the hospital only at the time of

delivery. So we do not know whether they have any pre-existing conditions or whether they are likely to get any complications," she says.

Dr Marwah adds that government centres like hers receive the most complicated cases and at the last moment, meaning the number of deaths are likely to be high at such centres. "While the number of maternal deaths has reduced significantly over the years, they continue to be a regular problem," she says.

Rajasthan is one of the states with less than the average national Maternal Mortality Rate. The national average has come down to 88 per lakh live births, inching closer to the sustainable development goal of 70. Rajasthan has an MMR of 87. While states such as Maharashtra (36), Tamil Nadu (38), and Andhra Pradesh (47) have a much lower MMR, there are several states with a much higher mortality number such as Madhya Pradesh (159), Chhattisgarh (141), and Uttar Pradesh (141), according to the latest available Sample Registration Survey data.

Delivery by caesarean section has been on the rise in the country --- increasing to 27.2% from 21.5% as per the recently released NFHS-6 data --- going up to as high as 40.5% in urban areas.

OWNER OF FACTORY IN MUNDKA AREA AMONG THREE ARRESTED

Three workers die in septic tank after inhaling toxic gas at Outer Delhi factory



Outside the factory where the incident happened. TASHI TOBGYAL

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 26

MARWAH PRINTERS in Outer Delhi's Mundka Industrial Area wore a deserted look on Friday evening. The black iron gate outside the two-floor factory with white paint scraping off its walls was locked. On the lane outside, was lying the sewage and blue gloves of three men who died after allegedly inhaling toxic gas in a septic tank at the factory earlier in the day.

A case has been registered under sections of Manual Scavenging act and the SC/ST ACT and three persons have been arrested. "Three people have been arrested — Suraj Marwah, the owner of Marwah Printers; aged 50; Jayant (61) and Neeraj (35), contractor for labourers. Further investigation is ongoing," said DCP (Outer) Vikram Singh. The deceased have been identified as Arun (38); Sandeep (32); and Chand (42), all residents of Sultanpuri in Outer Delhi, said a Delhi Fire Services (DFS) official.

According to police, a PCR call was received at Mundka police station regarding the incident and a team immediately

rushed to the spot.

During the preliminary inquiry, police said it was found that a printing unit had hired a contractor named Neeraj, a resident of Nangloi, to clean a septic tank located inside the factory premises in Gali No. 1 of Mundka Industrial Area.

"Neeraj, along with three other workers, was engaged in cleaning the tank when the incident took place. He allegedly told one of the workers that they have to get inside and clean out the garbage stuck in the machine," said a senior police officer. Rescue efforts were initiated soon after and the workers were pulled out. However, they could not be saved, according to officers. Police said the bodies have been shifted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital in Mangolpuri for post-mortem examination.

Officers said the autopsy will help determine the exact cause of death. Officials are also examining whether all mandatory safety protocols were followed before the cleaning operation began.

Police also said appropriate legal action is being taken under relevant provisions of law.

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 26

FOR RS 600, Arun left home on Friday morning.

The daily wage came only when work came. For the family, it meant groceries for a few days, school expenses for the children, and a little more time before financial worry returned.

By 10 am, Arun was still at home in Sultanpuri in Outer Delhi, where he lived with his wife, Aarti, and their three young sons in a two-room ground-floor house inside a cramped lane filled with hovering flies and a putrid stench.

A septic tank and sewage cleaner, Arun had not yet been called by his contractor, Naresh.

And then came the call. "He came to me and said, 'Neeraj bhai ne bulaya hai'. 'Tanki saaf krni hai, (Neeraj sir has called me. A tank has to be cleaned)' " says Aarti.

Arun left.

A few hours later, another call came. This one was to tell Aarti that her husband had fainted inside the septic tank.

"When I reached there, they said he is no more. I had seen him two hours ago. Why did he go inside? It was not his job," says Aarti, recalling that Arun was usually outside the tanks, operating what she calls the "tractor" — an informal term used among tank cleaners to denote the machine that

extracts sewage out of a tank using a pipe while other



Relatives of the deceased outside the mortuary of the Sanjay Gandhi Hospital in Mangolpuri on Friday. TASHI TOBGYAL

workers are inside the tank, pushing the waste towards the pipe.

As Aarti holds on to the couple's three boys — all between the ages of 6 and 8 — Arun's elder brother, Narender, says that he had been working with Neeraj for more than five years.

"They didn't give him any safety gear. He went there with his neighbours, Sandeep and Chand. They were asked on the phone to just remove the water from the tank. No one was supposed to go in," says Narender.

Arun was not the first one to go inside.

When the tractors couldn't clear the tank mechanically,

the contractor forced one of them to go in and clean it manually.

"Something got stuck inside. So, to clean it, the contractor forced Chand to go inside and clean it. He had been working with the contractor for a long time. He couldn't say no," says Shivani, nephew of Chand.

"We have still not told his wife and his two kids about the incident. They think he is admitted," adds Shivani, standing outside the mortuary of Sanjay Gandhi Hospital.

When Chand didn't come out after 10-odd minutes, Arun followed him inside.

Sandeep was waiting outside anxiously. Having recently

RECENT INCIDENTS IN THE CAPITAL

● **April 2026:** A young sanitation worker dies in East Delhi's Dilshad Garden after falling into a deep drain while cleaning it

● **September 2025:** A man (40) dies, 3 others hospitalised in critical condition after falling into a sewer in Northwest Delhi's Ashok Vihar

● **February 2025:** Two sanitation workers die, another injured while cleaning a sewage tank in Outer Delhi's Narela

● In 2023, Supreme Court told authorities to raise the compensation in sewer deaths from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 30 lakh

lost his job, Sandeep also couldn't afford to say no and had to jump in to save his neighbours, who had got him the contract through their reference.

About two lanes behind Arun's house, Sandeep's wife, Nisha, stands in front of the family's rented lodgings.

"I was leaving home for some work and Sandeep was still at home. I told him I would be back soon after dropping our daughter to school. By the time I came back, he wasn't there. My mother-in-law said that he had got some work," she says.

The next thing Nisha recalls is that her uncle called her to say that Sandeep was no more. "I have a 10-year-old daughter. My in-laws. What work am I supposed to find?" she says.

AMID SHORTAGE IN CAPITAL

Over 1.27 lakh vials of rabies vaccine undelivered due to lack of storage space, flags Serum Institute

Ankita Upadhyay
New Delhi, June 26

AMID A shortage of rabies vaccine across the government hospitals in the Capital, a consignment of over 1.27 lakh vials of anti-rabies vaccine meant for the city's public healthcare facilities has remained undelivered because the designated government warehouse lacks adequate cold storage capacity, according to a letter sent by the Serum Institute of India to the Central Procurement Agency (CPA), *The Indian Express* has learnt.

In the letter written on June 22, the Pune-based vaccine manufacturer said it had kept the entire consignment of 1,27,223 vials ready for dispatch for "a long time" under a supply order issued by the Directorate General of Health Services (DGHS) on March 27 this year.

Sources in the state health department said there is a dire shortage of rabies vaccines across Delhi government hospitals currently. "A couple of hospitals have managed to stock up in small quantities through local purchases but the majority of the hospitals do not have it," said an official source.

The Indian Express reached out to Serum Institute, officials at the DGHS and the CPA for a comment but a response was not received.

The firm — in the letter — said the supply order required the vaccines to be delivered to the Central Warehouse at the Super Specialty Hospital (SSH) in West Delhi's Janakpuri. However, when its representatives approached the warehouse, they were informed by the store keeper that the consignment could not be accepted because there was no cold storage space

available.

The Central Warehouse at Janakpuri Super Speciality Hospital (JSSH) manages the procurement, storage, and distribution of medical supplies, diagnostics, and medicines and maintains the vaccines and medicines that require temperature-controlled storage, commonly known as the cold chain, to remain safe and effective.

The anti-rabies vaccine requires strict temperature-controlled storage to maintain its efficacy.

In the letter, the Serum Institute requested the CPA, the nodal agency responsible for procuring medicines and equipment for public healthcare facilities, to identify an alternative delivery location where the vaccines could be received.

It also sought an extension of 20 days in the delivery timeline to enable completion of the supply after receiving confirmation of the revised delivery point.

The delay raises concerns over the availability of anti-rabies vaccines in Delhi's government healthcare system, particularly as the vaccine is administered as post-exposure prophylaxis following dog and animal bites.

The anti-rabies vaccine is important for the city as Delhi has witnessed a surge in stray dog attacks and rabies risks, with the Supreme Court last year expressing concern about such incidents.

According to the official data, Delhi recorded 51,773 dog bite cases in 2023.

In 2025, the figure reached 44,995 by August, underlining the scale of exposure risk and the need for robust surveillance.

● AT HUMANYUN'S TOMB MUSEUM

A date with a Renaissance master, his iconic depiction of mother and child

Anusree KC
New Delhi, June 26

IT WAS created more than five centuries ago, when Babur was yet to show up in India and Sikander Lodhi, who lies today in Lodhi Garden, was sultan of Delhi. It came to life in a studio in Florence where Sandro Botticelli lived and worked for most of his life, and significant portions of the artwork were likely created by the Early Renaissance master himself.

The home of the painting is Museo Stibbert in Florence — but you can now see it at the Havells Gallery at the Humayun's Tomb World Heritage Site Museum near Sunder Nursery, Nizamuddin.

The luminous tempera of Botticelli's Madonna and Child, which is dated to the dying years of the 15th century, is the only painting in the exhibition of artworks in stone, bronze, and clay.

The idea of the exhibition, which is ongoing until August 8, came together during a conversation over dinner between Andrea Anastasio, the director of the Italian Cultural Centre in India, and art historian Professor Naman P Ahuja of Jawaharlal Nehru University.

Anastasio had read Ahuja's essay, 'One Mother, Many Mother Tongues', first published by the Getty Foundation and subsequently by the arts magazine Marg in 2019, on the

representation of the bond between mother and child in art and literature down the ages.

"I told him, this would be fantastic. It's a dream if we can blend this variety with the iconography of motherhood in Italy and the Mediterranean, where the mother holding a child has been depicted in very powerful ways much before the Romans came," Anastasio said.

Ahuja agreed, and a year and a half of collaborative efforts followed to bring the exhibition to fruition. At its heart is the idea that Ahuja articulated in his paper — that the same image of the mother can be read through many mother tongues, regionally, culturally, personally.



Madonna and Child

Sandro Botticelli's Madonna and Child, loaned from the Museo Stibbert in Florence, is part of the exhibition 'One Mother, Many Mother Tongues', which is on view at the Havells Gallery, first floor, Museum Courtyard, Humayun Tomb Museum, until August 8. PHOTO COURTESY: GURDEEP SINGH, ITALIAN EMBASSY CULTURAL CENTRE

"When we work in advertising or media studies, the image has to appeal to multiple communities, religious groups, genders. The same image has to speak to a diverse group of people. I found a fantastic case study for that in Indian antiquity," Ahuja said.

The exhibition, he said, is not an argument for sameness, but a demonstration of productive difference.

Botticelli's workshop produced a whole series of Madonna and Child, depictions of the Virgin Mary and the infant Jesus, one of the most enduring

subjects in the history of art, to feed the demand for paintings on religious themes in the homes of wealthy Florentines.

The Museo Stibbert artwork was completed in 1496-97, and belongs to the final period of Botticelli's life (1445-1510), by when he had lost his primary benefactor, Lorenzo de' Medici, the de facto ruler of the Florentine republic and the greatest patron of Renaissance art.

Botticelli had by then all but abandoned the mythological grandeur of his earlier work and sunk into an almost obsess-

ive engagement with Madonna and Child, a theme he would paint some 40 times in the last two decades of his life.

"The [Museo Stibbert] Madonna is completely withdrawn in herself. She looks melancholic... So it's a beautiful blend of theological statement, philosophical understanding, and the search for formal beauty," Anastasio said.

The Museo Stibbert was set up by the English-Italian businessman Frederick Stibbert (1838-1906) using the vast fortune amassed in India by his

grandfather Giles Stibbert, an officer of the East India Company who fought in the Battle of Plassey in 1757, which led to the British taking over Bengal, and then the Battle of Buxar in 1764 in which the company defeated the combined armies of the Mughal emperor, the Nawabs of Oudh and Bengal, and the Maharaja of Benaras.

According to the Museo Stibbert website, Frederick Stibbert collected artworks for about 50 years to transform his sprawling residence in Monttighi, Florence, into a historical museum.

He left his collection to the Florence municipality in his will, and the museum was opened to the public in 1909.

India remains silent on Gaza, the world continues to speak up

IN SEPTEMBER 2025, the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory had concluded that Israeli authorities were committing genocide against Palestinians in Gaza. In June 2026, the same Commission — now headed by Justice (retired) S. Muralidhar, a distinguished Indian jurist — has poignantly reiterated that Israeli actions are intended to destroy the very existence of the Palestinians in Gaza by targeting their children.

The 94-page report is a harrowing read, with grim details on the extent of the devastation perpetrated by Israel in Gaza and the genocidal intent underpinning its actions. At least 20,000 children have been killed, and another 44,000 have been wounded, many for life. The targeting of children is not incidental, but a deliberate strategy. Twenty-seven per cent of those killed or wounded have been children and many of the boys were found with bullets on the head and neck. Ninety-seven per cent of Gaza's schools have been destroyed. Healthcare infrastructure, including paediatric hospitals, has been destroyed, resulting in a 300 per cent increase in miscarriage and childbirth complications.

In the two-and-a-half years since the dastardly, horrific, and absolutely unacceptable attack by Hamas on Israel, it has become clear that the retaliation of the Israeli armed forces and political leadership has been characterised by wanton cruelty and barbarity. Senior Israeli leaders, down from Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and his senior cabinet colleagues themselves, have called for the “complete siege” and “total annihilation” of Gaza, denounced the Palestinians as

“animals” who have “no right to exist,” and defined success for Israel as “hundreds of thousands fleeing Gaza”.

Despite this clear genocidal intent, the support of President Donald Trump's government in Washington DC has enabled the Israeli government to continue its brutal campaign against Palestinians. But the rest of the world has felt the pricking of its conscience.

The UN has been unable to act with any resolve due to American obstruction, but through its agencies it has played a stellar role in the documentation of Israeli war crimes. Leading powers historically associated with the Western bloc — including France, the UK, Canada, and Australia — have recognised Palestinian statehood after decades of indifference to the Palestinian cause. South Africa, a country with which India has shared a long history of anti-colonial solidarity, has dragged Israel to the International Court of Justice for its violations of the Genocide Convention of 1948. Several European states have restricted arms sales to Israel, and several Latin American nations have downgraded or severed their ties with the country. The International Criminal Court has even issued arrest warrants for the Israeli political leadership. A very large number of countries with whom India enjoys close relations have recognised Israel's actions in Gaza as genocide.

Amidst the growing public backlash against Israel and the international community's cognisance of the unjustifiable brutality unleashed on Gaza, India remains a lone voice of silence. Justice Mu-



SONIA GANDHI

We are slipping further into Israel's strategic orbit, at a time when the world is increasingly pivoting away from it. The Prime Minister's visit to Israel a will go down in history as a bewildering strategic decision

ralidhar's report, which has sparked renewed conversation and activism against the Gaza genocide, has been met with stony silence from the Narendra Modi government. It is hardly surprising — recall that Justice Muralidhar had been transferred out of the Delhi High Court after he called out the Delhi Police's inaction on BJP leaders' inflammatory statements in the run-up to the 2020 Delhi riots.

India was historically exceptional among the nations of the world for our commitment to postcolonial solidarity, national sovereignty, and international peace. Today we are exceptional in our continued indifference to the flagrant violation of the global rules-based order, to the suffering of our fellow peoples in the Global South, and to the abasement of human dignity that is on open display in Gaza and the West Bank.

Hind Rajab's tragic story is emblematic of the unspeakable cruelty of the Israeli genocide in Gaza — a girl of just five, fleeing Gaza City with her family when Israeli forces fired 335 rounds at their car, killing her six family members, leaving her trapped in a car with her relatives' dead bodies while paramedics attempted to rescue her. She was eventually killed, along with two paramedics. The citizens of India, as citizens of the world, have a right to know the story of Hind Rajab and countless other Palestinian children. Yet, to defer to Israel's sensitivities, the movie was blocked for months in India, and has only now been cleared under immense public pressure.

The Modi government's silence and inaction are not just mo-

rally reprehensible but also inexplicable from a national interest perspective. We are slipping further into Israel's strategic orbit, at a time when the world is increasingly pivoting away from it. The Prime Minister's visit to Israel amidst these circumstances, and only days before Israel's war on Iran and the assassination of its top political leadership, will go down in history as a bewildering strategic decision. We have alienated ourselves from our historical allies in Palestine, Iran, and the larger Middle East. We have distanced ourselves from global public opinion. And we have let Pakistan, of all countries, itself a state that has and continues to harbour dreaded terrorists, swoop in to claim the space of a mediator — a role to which we would have a natural claim given our historically friendly ties with all players. Our sacrifice of our strategic interest and morality has yielded us nothing but the friendship between Prime Minister Modi and Prime Minister Netanyahu, who is now under attack all over the world, including in the USA.

The spirit of Indian nationhood demands that we speak up for our Palestinian brothers and sisters whose children have been so brutally targeted. The calculus of national interest demands that we respond to the global public opinion against the Israeli regime's genocidal actions in Gaza and its brutal displacement and dispossession of lakhs of Palestinian families in the occupied West Bank. The Modi government's continued silence simply cannot be explained rationally or morally.

The writer is chairperson of the Congress Parliamentary Party

More children isn't the answer to delimitation, tax challenges



C RANGARAJAN



J K SATIA

RECENTLY, THE Sample Registration System (SRS) and the sixth round of the National Family Health Survey (NFHS) released their results. What do they say about India's future population size? A University of Washington team had estimated India's total fertility rate (TFR) to be 1.9 in 2017, and its model showed that the population in India will peak at 160 crore in 2048. However, this estimate is optimistic as SRS estimates TFR to be 1.9 in 2024. The UN Population Division periodically updates its population projections and has estimated that the population is likely to peak at 170 crore in 2062 and decline thereafter. In view of the recent data, this is perhaps the most likely scenario.

There is very gradual progress, and, therefore, problems persist. The sex ratio at birth was estimated to be 918 in 2022-24, signifying a persistent “girl deficit” as the normal ratio is 955. It was 907 in 2018-2020. At this pace of increase, it will take 13 years to reach the normal rate, and the “girl deficit” will continue for even longer.

The most significant problem is the demographic divergence among states. The two highest-fertility states are Bihar and Uttar Pradesh at TFRs of 2.9 and 2.6 respectively, compared to 1.9 for India as a whole. At the current pace of decline in TFR, Bihar and UP will take 18 and 10 years to reach the replacement rate of 2.1, the rate at which the population size stabilises over a period of time.

One could argue that the way to reduce this divergence is to accelerate the decline in fertility of high-fertility states and increase it in low-fertility states. Let us examine each. Women's empowerment and contraception broadly determine the pace of fertility decline. The female population (aged six years and above) who ever attended school was 73.7 per cent for all India, but much lower in Bihar and UP at 64.1 per cent and 70.1 per cent respectively. Women with 10 or more years of schooling constituted 46.4 per cent at the all-India level but stood at 33.1 per cent and 42.5 per cent respectively in Bihar and UP. Use of any method of contraception among married women (15-49 years of age) was 69.1 per cent at the all-India

level and 59.3 per cent and 62.4 per cent in Bihar and UP respectively. Clearly, women's empowerment efforts as well as family welfare programmes to enable them to meet their fertility intentions need to be accelerated in these states.

What can be done to increase fertility in low-fertility states? Recently, Andhra Pradesh announced a new population management policy to address declining fertility, which includes (a) a one-time payment of Rs 30,000 for the third child and Rs 40,000 for the fourth child; and (b) a monthly nutrition stipend of Rs 1,000 for the third child, free education up to the age of 18 and extended maternity leave. While researching imminent population decline in Sweden in 1945, Alva Myrdal, in her book *Nation and Family*, commented that one-off measures are most unlikely to work.

However, the question is: Is it necessary for any state to increase its fertility rate? In India, differential growth rates in population may have implications beyond the purely economic. Currently, delimitation is a big question. No state wants to lose its importance in the political system. This needs to be tackled through means other than population policy.

There is no case for any state to raise the fertility rate. We are still quite far away from stabilising our population. Lack of population is not what is hindering the states from growing faster. What is needed is to prevent the level of population from determining political clout. In the case of tax devolution, the problem was solved by introducing two criteria — the level of population and demographic performance — in determining the states' shares.

India needs to pay more attention to population quantity and quality issues. The NFHS estimates of the TFR for Bihar and UP are lower than the SRS estimates. If so, this will quicken the time to achieve stability. We have to await Census results to get more definitive data on population issues.

Rangarajan is former chairman, PM-EAC, and former governor, RBI, and Satia is professor emeritus, Indian Institute of Public Health

India-China cooperation can make Asian century a reality



XU WEI

THE WORLD stands at a turbulent crossroads. Hegemony, unilateralism and protectionism are exacerbating global deficits in peace, development, security and governance. As the only two nations with populations exceeding 1.4 billion, the complexity of the India-China relationship is unmatched. With the centre of global gravity shifting to Asia, relations have transcended the bilateral scope. Our combined contribution of over 40 per cent to global growth positions us as active architects of solutions. By joining hands, China and India can transform Eastern wisdom into a stabilising force in the world. President Xi Jinping's four global initiatives constitute a coherent framework rooted in our shared philosophical traditions. These initiatives offer practical pathways for synergy between China and India.

The Global Development Initiative (GDI) seeks to put development at the top of the global agenda. This dovetails with India's mission of *Viksit Bharat 2047*. Both nations understand development is an inalienable right. The GDI advocates for green, inclusive growth, urging a move away from zero-sum competition. By aligning our development paradigms, we can ensure that modernisation benefits all.

The Global Security Initiative champions common, comprehensive, cooperative, sustainable security. Its fundamental principles — respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity, adherence to the principles of the UN Charter, and the peaceful resolution of disputes — directly echo the *Panchsheel* (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence), which India and China pioneered decades ago. For neighbours sharing a vast border, the GSI is a timely reminder that true security cannot be achieved by any single nation at the expense of others. Mutual trust remains the most reliable instrument for managing differences.

The Global Civilisation Initiative advocates respect for the diversity of world civilisations, promoting equality, mutual learning, dialogue, and inclusiveness. This resonates with India's philosophy of *vasudhaiva kutumbakam*. As ancient civilisations that have shaped human history for millennia, we share the wisdom that no single culture holds a monopoly on truth. Through civilisational exchanges and mutual learning, we can overcome estrangement, break the “clash of civilisations” narrative, and build a world where people of all nations understand each other.

The Global Governance Initiative aims to build a more just and equitable global system. Its fundamental task is to uphold the authority and status of the UN; the key lies in major countries demonstrating their responsibilities; and the most pressing task is to close peace and development deficits. No country can achieve development by placing itself outside the global governance system, nor secure its future without international cooperation. Artificial isolation only leads to confrontation.

China and India have the responsibility to safeguard Asia's peace and solidarity. So long as we respect each other's core interests and succeed together, we will inject positive energy into global development, security, civilisation, and governance. Together, we can make the Asian century a reality for all.

The writer is consul-general of the People's Republic of China in Kolkata

Delhi-Dhaka thaw welcome. Build on it

IN THE Indian Subcontinent, a perceived “big brother” attitude vis a vis smaller neighbours is often a problem, and must be addressed through patient diplomatic engagement and the promise of tangible gains from the relationship. For the better part of two decades, until the ouster of former Bangladesh prime minister Sheikh Hasina on August 4, 2024, Delhi and Dhaka had arguably the most consequential relationship in the region. The chill in ties that accompanied the regime change in Bangladesh, then, was a major cause for worry. However, recent moves from both sides — most recently, the announcement that India would resume issuing tourist visas at pre-2024 levels — show that a much-needed thaw is underway. This must be built on.

The trust deficit between the two countries came to the fore almost immediately after the Muhammad Yunus-led interim government took charge. New Delhi expressed concern at the attacks on Awami League supporters, and on those belonging to the minority community. Measures like the withdrawal of transshipment facilities for Bangladesh's export cargo earlier this year would have worried Dhaka. With the benefit of hindsight, India did not do enough to send the message that the value of the bilateral relationship did not depend on which party held sway in Dhaka. It rests, instead, on the deep affinities between the people of both countries. Fortunately, since the elevation of Tarique Rahman as PM, both sides have made efforts to correct the course. Meetings between leaders, including between PM Rahman and India's External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, have sent out a positive message. As has India's supply of fuel to its neighbour during the West Asia crisis.

Whether in bodies like the BIMSTEC, or for India's larger ambitions in the Indian Ocean Region or its Act East policy, Dhaka remains an essential partner. Equally, Bangladesh cannot wish away the geographical and economic reality of its larger neighbour. On river-water sharing, the 4,000-km land border, power and a host of other issues, the two countries have much to gain through cooperation. For this potential to be realised, both must sidestep the rhetoric of short-term politics.

Lack of population is not what is hindering the states from growing faster. What is needed is to prevent the level of population from determining political clout

The Ideas Page

SATURDAY, JUNE 27, 2026

A passport that doesn't count, a narrowing idea of citizenship



FAIZAN MUSTAFA

CITIZENSHIP IS a vertical relationship between the individual and the state. Originally, citizenship used to signify a belief in certain liberal and republican ideas and did not have much to do with territory and status. Today, it is all about territory, status, and exclusion rather than inclusion. The Foreigners' Tribunals in Assam reportedly denied citizenship to people despite some possessing as many as 15 documents. The judiciary, too, has become quite restrictive in this regard.

In Shabbir Hussain's (1951) case — a trader who got stuck in Lahore during Partition and returned to India only on a temporary permit but was subsequently arrested for overstaying in India — the apex court refused to treat him as a Pakistani national. Similarly, in *Abdul Khader* (1960), the Supreme Court refused to treat Khader as a foreigner despite his having a Pakistani passport. But in *Izhar Ahmad Khan* (1962), the Court treated possession of a Pakistani passport as conclusive proof of Pakistani citizenship. By 2008, the Court had become even more restrictive when, in *Razia Begum*, it held that even possession of an Indian passport was not sufficient proof of citizenship.

B R Ambedkar said that the citizenship provisions of the Constitution had given the Constitution's Drafting Committee "a headache". Yet, the citizenship topic was considered so settled that no constitutional law syllabus included it with prominence. After the Citizenship Amendment Act, 2019 (CAA), citizenship became the most important subject not only for law students but for the masses. Though the government enacted the CAA with great alacrity, it took five years to notify its rules. The Special Intensive Revision (SIR) in Bihar in 2025 and other states in 2026 has once again brought the citizenship debate to the centre stage.

The SC, in its Bihar SIR judgment, held that the passport is "conclusive proof" of citizenship. The latest clarification by the Min-



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

istry of External Affairs (MEA) has explicitly said it is nothing more than a travel document. Strictly in terms of law and judgments, the MEA is correct. But since the government does not issue any citizenship card or certificate, how should one prove their citizenship? Why hasn't a single resident of Assam among the 3.11 crore people whose citizenship was proved during the NRC exercise been issued a citizenship card? Is the latest clarification a precursor to such a document? If yes, not only will people have to queue up like during demonetisation, but just like the Assam NRC, an overwhelming number of Indians won't be able to prove their citizenship. In Assam, a majority of the 19 lakh excluded people were Hindus.

Article 5, on the commencement of the Constitution, conferred citizenship on everyone born in India. Article 11 empowers Parliament to regulate citizenship by law, and thus the Citizenship Act was passed in 1955. It has been amended six times, but major amendments were made in 1986, 2003, and 2019. Parliament, over the decades, has narrowed the universal principles of citizenship incorporated in Article 5. Unlike the original Act, which gave citizenship on the principle of *jus soli* or by birth, the 1986 amendment was less

inclusive as it added the condition that, in addition to one's own birth in India, one can get citizenship only if either parent was an Indian citizen at the time of birth. In 2003, an amendment under the Vajpayee government added that either both parents should be Indian citizens or one must be an Indian citizen and the other should not be an illegal migrant. With these restrictive amendments, India has almost moved towards the narrow principle of *jus sanguinis* — blood relationships become more important than birth on Indian soil.

Based on these provisions, how is Indian citizenship to be proved? Section 2(1)(e) of the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023, says evidence can be either oral or documentary. "Proved" under Section 2(1)(f) means that after considering the matters before it, the court believes such a fact to exist or a prudent man would act upon the supposition that it exists. The crucial point is that "proved" is a subjective state of mind of the judge. "Disproved" under Section 2(1)(c) means a belief that it does not exist. The third concept is "conclusive proof", which under Section 2(1)(b) means that if a fact is declared by the evidence law as conclusive proof of another, on the proof of that fact, the court shall not allow

evidence to disprove it. Since today, a passport, Aadhaar, or voter ID card is not taken as "conclusive" proof of citizenship, evidence can certainly be given to disprove someone's citizenship status.

But evidence law also provides for certain "presumptions of fact" and "presumptions of law". Section 2(1)(h) lays down that whenever this law provides the court may presume a fact, it may regard it as proved unless it is disproved. Section 2(1)(l) says that when the evidence law directs that the court shall presume a fact, it shall regard it as proved unless and until it is disproved. Thus, in cases of rape where sexual intercourse by the accused is proved, Section 120 provides for the presumption that it was without consent.

Since passports and voter ID cards can be issued only to citizens, why is there no presumption of citizenship? Is this not an official act? Many of us have experienced police verification prior to the issuance of passports. Passport, voter ID, etc., require governmental satisfaction about citizenship. Section 78 of the Sakshya Adhiniyam says the court shall presume every document to be genuine if it is declared by law as evidence of any particular fact and is certified by any government officer. Section 104 says the one who asserts a fact bears the burden of proof. Shouldn't anyone who questions someone's citizenship despite a passport or voter ID bear the burden of proving such an assertion?

During the SIR, the EC insisted on certain documents and arbitrarily excluded Aadhaar and its own voter ID card, which the Supreme Court did not find problematic. But none of the documents included was a proof of citizenship. Under the law of estoppel, the government cannot deny citizenship to those to whom it had issued a passport or voter ID card, unless the same were obtained fraudulently. This author's own first passport explicitly certified him as a citizen. Why has this seal of citizenship been dropped? The proof of citizenship should be demanded only from those who are caught while crossing over to India, or a foreigner found in India with a passport of another country, or those born abroad. For anyone born in India, there must be a presumption of citizenship, and voter ID and a passport must be taken as conclusive proof of citizenship.

The writer is vice-chancellor, Chanakya National Law University, Patna. Views are personal

Since passports and voter ID cards can be issued only to citizens, why is there no presumption of citizenship? Is this not an official act?



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

THE UNION Home Ministry promulgated new Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) rules earlier this week, which seek to restrict the activities of NGOs that receive foreign funding. The rules say that the foreign contributions can be used for the construction or maintenance of religious places, printing and digitisation of sacred scriptures, building facilities for pilgrims, running community kitchens and promoting indigenous and tribal faith practices. However, they ban proselytisation activity using foreign money.

Even before the amendments were formally gazetted, they created ripples not only across India but even in the US. The proposed amendments to the FCRA became an electoral issue during the recent assembly elections in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The ripples reached Capitol Hill in Washington, DC too. James Risch, who heads the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, threatened that the US "will not hesitate to call out countries who violate the internationally recognised human rights of Christians".

After Independence, states like Orissa (1967), Madhya Pradesh (1968), and Arunachal Pradesh (1978) introduced anti-conversion laws. They were followed by Chhattisgarh (2000), Gujarat (2003), Himachal Pradesh (2006), Jharkhand (2017), Uttarakhand (2018), Uttar Pradesh (2021), Haryana (2022), Ra-

In 'Rev. Stainislaus vs State of Madhya Pradesh' (1977), the SC stated that while Article 25 gives freedom to choose one's religion, it does not give the right to convert other persons

jasthan (2025) and Maharashtra (2026).

Several Christian groups insist that the "right to propagate" includes "right to proselytise". However, in *Rev. Stainislaus vs State of Madhya Pradesh* (1977), the SC stated that while Article 25 of the Constitution gives freedom to choose one's religion, it does not give the right to convert other persons. The government's move is in line with that verdict.

Before Independence, reformers and leaders like Ram Mohan Roy, Vivekananda and Gandhi raised serious questions over conversions. In an interview in March 1931, when a journalist asked whether he would favour the retention of foreign missionaries in India after Independence, Gandhi's reply was, "If instead of confining themselves purely to humanitarian work and material service to the poor, they do proselytising by means of medical aid, education, I would certainly ask them to withdraw". In another interview in Harijan on May 11, 1935, he stated, "If I had power and could legislate, I should certainly stop all proselytising. It is the cause of much avoidable conflict".

Jawaharlal Nehru, however, reassured missionaries in 1946. "Christians form the third-largest group in the country, and it is absurd for anyone to imagine that their religious or other rights can be suppressed," he said. In the Constituent Assembly, issues like "propaganda" or "propagation" and "conversions" were debated. Congress

had earlier promised freedom to "profess and practise" religion in its election manifesto. But the missionaries demanded the "right to propagate" that included the right to convert. Members like KM Munshi, Alladi Krishnaswami Aiyer and C Rajagopalachari took a contrarian view on the right to conversion. Sardar Patel and Maulana Azad insisted that missionaries must abjure mass conversions. But most such suggestions could not muster a majority support in the Assembly. Finally, Article 19, which included the phrase "to propagate religion," became the law.

Questions continued to be raised over missionary work. The Niyogi Committee, appointed by the Madhya Pradesh Government in 1954 to look into the activities of the missionaries in the state's tribal areas, came out with a stinging report against missionaries. Its recommendations included: The missionaries whose primary object is proselytisation should be asked to withdraw, and the influx of foreign missionaries should be checked. The Constitution should be amended in order to rule out propagation by foreigners and conversions by illicit means, and legislative measures should be enacted for controlling conversion by illegal means.

The Nehru government rubbished the committee's claims. Seven decades later, the Modi government is taking steps to implement those recommendations.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

A long-overdue correction on conversion

TEL AVIV, BEIRUT HAD BEEN DISCUSSING POTENTIAL ISRAELI WITHDRAWALS FROM SOUTHERN LEBANON

Israel, Lebanon sign framework peace deal after US-brokered talks

Talks aim to end fighting between Israel, Hezbollah

Reuters
Jerusalem, Beirut,
Washington, June 26

ISRAEL AND Lebanon signed a framework agreement in Washington on Friday following several days of talks to secure an end to fighting between Israel and Iran-backed Hezbollah militants. Lebanese Ambassador Nada Moawad and her Israeli counterpart Yechiel Leiter signed the trilateral document with the US at the State Department in Washington.

“Today we’ve taken the first step in what will be a difficult journey, without a doubt, but an important and an essential and a necessary one,” US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said before the agreement was inked.

The conflict between Israel and Hezbollah broke out when the armed group fired at Israel on March 2, days after the US and Israel attacked Iran.

The Hezbollah attacks triggered Israeli air and ground attacks that have killed more than



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, State Department Counselor Daniel Holler, Israeli Ambassador Yechiel Leiter and Lebanese Ambassador Nada Hamadeh sign a framework deal in Washington, on Friday. REUTERS

4,000 people in Lebanon and displaced more than a million.

The officials did not provide details of the framework deal and did not say how its terms would differ from those included in an April 16 ceasefire deal that preceded several rounds of US-brokered Israel-Lebanon talks.

“The trilateral framework we signed today is a first step on the road to restoring Lebanese sovereignty and territorial integrity,

securing a permanent and final cessation of hostilities, enabling our people to go back to their land, and allowing all Lebanese to live in peace, security, and prosperity,” Moawad said.

Leiter praised Moawad for negotiating like a “lioness.” “In this performance-based trilateral framework agreement, Iran is out, Hezbollah is out, and the road to peace between Israel and Lebanon is in,” he said.

They did not take questions

from reporters.

Israel’s death toll from this round of hostilities with Hezbollah includes at least 32 soldiers and four Israeli civilians. Hezbollah does not release figures on its war dead. Reuters reported on May 4 that several thousand Hezbollah fighters had been killed in the war.

The talks in Washington have included discussions on a proposal for Israeli forces to hand some of the territory they

occupied in southern Lebanon to Lebanon’s military.

A State Department official told Reuters on Thursday that Israel had agreed to pull back from some of that territory, something Israeli and Lebanese officials denied.

Before the talks resumed this week, Israel and Hezbollah agreed to halt fire even as Israel kept troops in occupied southern Lebanon -- territory it describes as a “buffer zone” aimed at thwarting Hezbollah attacks on northern Israel.

Violence has persisted since the ceasefire, with Israel saying on Friday its troops had struck and killed what the military described as seven Hezbollah members who were operating near the territory it is occupying. Reuters could not confirm this.

Israeli forces dropped leaflets over the southern Lebanese town of Mansouri on Friday ordering residents to leave, Lebanese state media reported, the first such order issued since the latest ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah took effect.

A senior Lebanese military official said Israel had recently added Mansouri to its occupation zone. The official said Lebanese farmers had continued to enter and leave the town, but had not been living there.

Australia pledges tougher laws to keep kids below 16 away from social media

Associated Press
Melbourne, June 26

THE AUSTRALIAN government plans to strengthen laws that ban children younger than 16 from social media platforms, Prime Minister Anthony Albanese said.

Observers said on Friday the government was responding to evidence that the ban on young children holding accounts on platforms including Facebook, Instagram and YouTube had failed since it came into force on Dec. 10 last year. Australia was the first country in the world to pass legislation keeping youth off social media, but others have since followed.

Albanese told Parliament on Thursday this government was considering options to strengthen the ban.

“We’re working on that as a priority because this is something that other generations didn’t have to deal with, which is why it’s complex,” Albanese



Prime Minister Anthony Albanese

told Parliament.

He told the Australian Broadcasting Corp. on Friday the government was asking “are the laws as strong as possible?” and did eSafety Commissioner Julie Inman Grant, Australia’s online safety watchdog, “have every power at her disposal?”

Britain announced last week plans to ban children under 16 from a range of platforms to protect them from harmful content and excessive screen time.

● A LOOSE COLLECTIVE OF CYBERCRIMINALS INITIALLY TOOK CREDIT FOR CRIPPLING JAGUAR LAND ROVER LAST YEAR; INVESTIGATORS NOW SEE RUSSIAN HANDS BEHIND THE RANSOMWARE ATTACK

The \$2.5 billion whodunit: A cyber attack that left a dent in Britain’s economy

Adam Goldman, Jane Bradley, Dustin Volz & Michael Schwirtz
June 26

LAST YEAR, hackers burrowed into the computer systems of Jaguar Land Rover, a crown jewel of British manufacturing. It was a devastating attack that forced Jaguar to lock down its computers and suspend production for five weeks. The hack even put a dent in the broader economy, making it the costliest cyberattack in nation’s history.

The hack was alarming, but also mysterious. There was never a demand for money, as is common in such intrusions. A loose collective of hackers that

included some in Britain took credit. Their claim led to news media speculation that they were the culprits.

They were not. A group of Russian hackers was responsible, according to five people familiar with an investigation into the hack. They spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the case.

Law enforcement and private-sector cyber-response specialists from Britain and the United States determined that the attack was different in methodology and motivation from the hacking collective, said four of the people.

Authorities are still sorting through the murky details trying

to determine whether the attackers were operating at the behest of the Kremlin, or with its tacit assent.

The hack in late August 2025, and its economic impact were widely covered. In October, The Telegraph newspaper reported that authorities were looking into whether Russia was involved. The conclusion by government and some private-sector investigators that the group was Russian has not been previously reported.

Hacking by Russian groups is hardly new. Still, the attack on Jaguar — and the potential involvement of the Russian state — raises the possibility that this was not typical ransom



Land Rovers being transported from the Jaguar Land Rover factory in Solihull, England. NYT

attack but an assault on the economic foundation of a sovereign state. It played into longstanding fears that an adversa-

rial state could remotely paralyze critical infrastructure, like an energy grid or key manufacturers, stoking chaos and caus-

ing economic damage.

The Jaguar infiltration had profound consequences. It slowed manufacturing in the third quarter of 2025, delivering an estimated \$2.5 billion hit to the British economy, and it cost the company about \$350 million in the 2026 fiscal year.

It also carried powerful symbolism. King Charles III and Queen Camilla use Jaguar vehicles, and the British military has relied on its iconic Land Rover fleet for decades.

New reporting by The New York Times uncovered other details of the investigation. Microsoft, for instance, had been tracking the Russian group and alerted Jaguar to who had

breached its systems, according to four of the people familiar with the case. The hackers had used novel ransomware with an encryption algorithm that some cybersecurity experts had not seen in previous attacks. One described it as “mind-blowing.”

Inside a hastily arranged war room during the episode, Jaguar huddled with cybersecurity investigators and private sector experts. Among those participating were Britain’s National Crime Agency and National CyberSecurity Centre, as well as Palo Alto Networks and Google’s Mandiant unit.

The FBI also assisted. They raced to contain the malware even as the hackers hurriedly

tried to erase their footprints.

The attack on Jaguar took place amid an increasingly hostile relationship between Russia and Britain, whose military assistance to Ukraine has angered the Kremlin. Britain has also mounted its own secret cyberintrusion and sabotage operations against Russia, according to former British and American intelligence officials.

A spokesperson for Britain’s National Crime Agency said that it knows that “some of the most high-profile cyberattacks against the UK are committed by criminals operating from within Russia, and that some of the groups responsible have links to the Russian state.” NYT

THE STATEMENT COMES AT A TIME WHEN US-INDIA TRADE DEAL TALKS ARE IN FINAL PHASE

Tariff rates may return to ‘exactly where they were’, signals Bessent

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 26

AS INDIAN negotiators have pressed for more clarity on Section 301 tariffs and the need for a competitive edge over other countries before signing a trade deal, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has said that the tariffs will return to the previous levels with the use of Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974.

“We have rebooted the tariff program. Right now, we have something called Section 122 tariffs, which is a 10% global tariff. Currently, USTR Ambassador Jameson Greer is doing studies for Section 301s, and if those studies are successful, and I have no reason to believe they won’t be, but we don’t know until they are — then the tariff rates are going to go back to exactly where they were,” Bessent said in a TV interview.

The International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs on India were set at 25% before it was brought down to 18% in February, just days before the US President

SEESAW GAME

THE INTERNATIONAL Emergency Economic Powers Act tariffs on India were set at 25% before it was brought down to 18% in February, just days before the US President Donald Trump’s powers under the IEEPA were declared illegal

WASHINGTON HAS already proposed 12.5% tariffs on India, which is expected to come into effect on July 7

THE RESULTS of another Section 301 investigation are also



expected before the end of next month.

Donald Trump’s powers under the IEEPA were declared illegal.

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The results of another Section 301 are also expected before the end of next month.

“I would say the good thing about having used IEEPA in 2025... it allowed us very quickly to get to trade deals that

we never would have gotten to before. You know, the EU... the EU is going to pay us 15%, and they are going to charge us zero. So we have had a big rebalancing there. And they are bringing down their non-tariff trade barriers, many of their unfair financing practices. And it’s the same around the world, whether it’s Japan, Korea, our allies... whether it’s China,” he said. The Commerce and In-

dustrial Minister on Thursday said that the India-US trade deal was confirmed by both the countries on February 6 based on IEEPA tariffs, which gave India a competitive edge over competing countries such as Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Indonesia, Malaysia and China and that India is looking for a similar advantage in the new US tariffs architecture.

Meanwhile, India has accelerated its attempts to strike more and more trade deals. The UK trade deal is set to come into effect next month, EU by the end of the year. The India-Oman deal also came into effect on June 1.

Indian negotiators are also in talks with the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), Canada, Peru and Chile.

Notably, the United States Trade Representative (USTR) was due to visit Uzbekistan after India this week. While the India-US deal was not announced, the US and Uzbekistan agreed to an early harvest of trade commitments to strengthen the bilateral ties.

USTR had launched two

sets of broad Section 301 investigations based on forced labour and excess capacity. India, China, the European Union, Japan, Vietnam, Taiwan, Switzerland and South Korea feature in both the lists, and the US has already proposed the first set of tariffs.

However, countries like the UAE, the UK, Israel, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, as well as Pakistan only feature once and may face lower tariffs compared to other countries.

US proposed a lower rate of 10% on Pakistan, Canada, Ecuador, the European Union, Indonesia and Mexico, stating that they have demonstrated a commitment to addressing forced labour imports and have committed to imposing and enforcing a forced labour import prohibition through a formal Agreement on Reciprocal Trade (ART) with the United States. Separately, the US has launched a third investigation on Vietnam and a fresh case against Germany. China has also been facing Section 301 tariffs since Trump’s first administration.

Goldman Sachs hikes India’s FY27 growth forecast to 6.5%

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 26

GLOBAL INVESTMENT and financial services firm Goldman Sachs has raised its calendar year 2026 real GDP growth forecast for India by 30 basis points to 6.8% and FY27 forecast by 40 bps to 6.5% in the wake of the fall in crude oil prices.

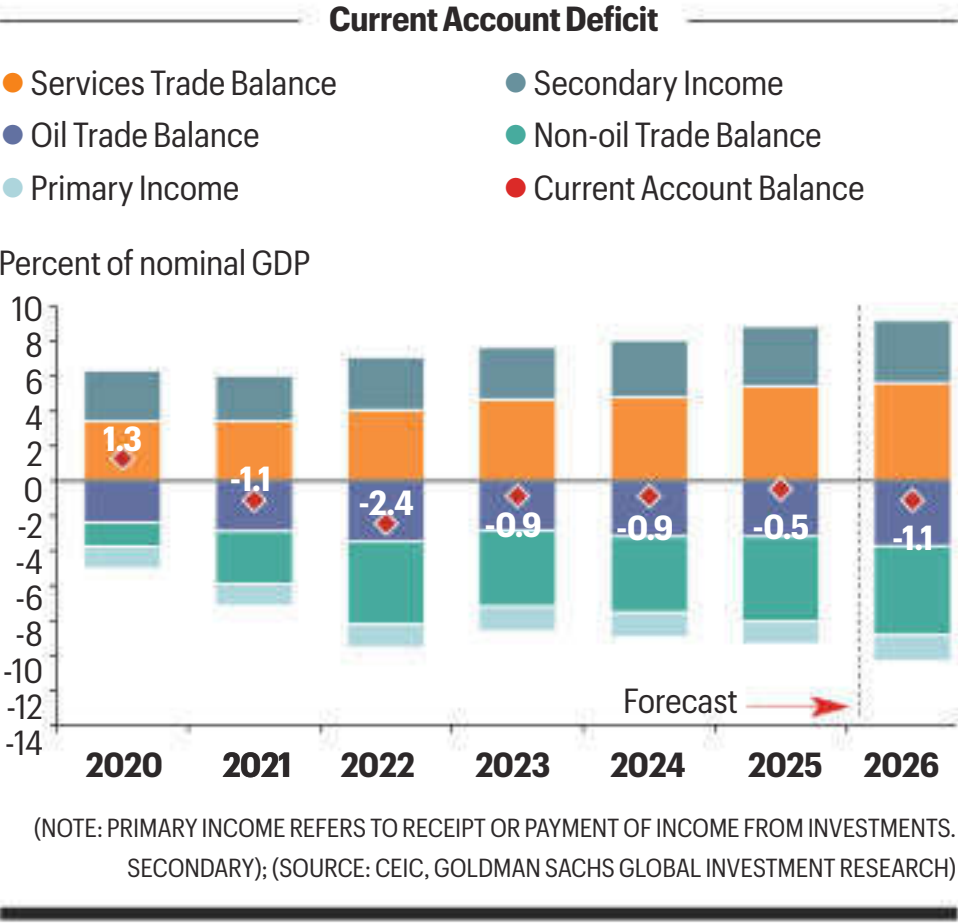
The recent US-Iran peace deal should improve India’s growth outlook — lower oil prices have taken out the risk of additional fuel pass-through to consumers, while easing supply constraints were already beginning to support a recovery in investment related indicators in May from their March-April troughs, the firm said in a report. On June 5, the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%. International benchmark Brent crude futures for August were 3.2% lower at \$72.83 a barrel on Friday.

“While the fuel price hikes already announced will continue to feed through into inflation over the coming months, the lower oil price path suggests that the risk of additional pass-through has diminished materially,” Goldman Sachs said.

The firm said lower crude oil prices have also been accompanied by a decline in petrochemical product prices.

“Although the earlier increases in polymer price are still likely to lift core goods inflation in the near term, we now expect the impact to be limited (vs. our earlier expectations), with a lower likelihood of incremental price increases across the core goods basket,” it said. Reflecting the lower oil price assumptions

OIL BOOST



and reduced manufactured goods inflation pressures, Goldman Sachs lowered its core goods inflation forecast for CY26 and FY27 by 30 basis points and 50 bps each to 3.2% and 4.1% respectively.

“Going forward, we expect consumption growth to moderate in Q2 and Q3 on earlier pump fuel price increases. We have also seen deterioration in the RBI’s urban and rural consumer confidence surveys (90.7 in May vs. 93.2 in April for the urban confidence index),” Goldman Sachs said.

However, the recent decline in oil prices reduces the likelihood of further fuel price increases, implying no further incremental drag on consumption growth from Q4, it said.

Further, the sharp correction in global urea prices is likely to limit the increase in the government’s fertilizer subsidy

bill relative to the earlier expectations. “Recent import tenders have cleared at substantially lower prices than those seen at the peak of the Middle East conflict, prompting the government to indicate that the FY27 fertilizer subsidy requirement could be reassessed. Together with lower oil prices, this should help alleviate near-term fiscal pressures,” it said.

Goldman Sachs said the Indian economy remained resilient through the West-Asia shock, as fiscal and quasi-fiscal measures absorbed much of the increase in energy costs and limited pass-through to consumers. As a result, consumption held up in March and April, even as investment somewhat softened amid supply disruptions and commercial LPG allocations remained around 70% of pre-conflict levels, it said.

• POLICY

What a ‘right to walk’ can look like for India



EXPERT EXPLAINS

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LAST WEEK, the Supreme Court recognised walking on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right and urged the government to introduce a law that declares this right. The two-judge bench’s ruling came in a case involving the death of a schoolboy in a road accident.

India has the dubious distinction of having the world’s highest number of road accident fatalities. The court identified this as the result of the exclusion of pedestrians in the way roads are built.

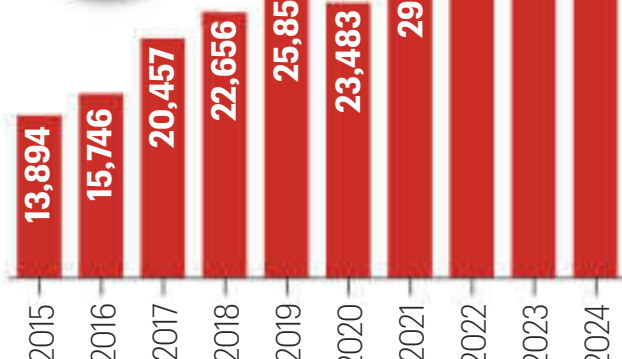
The issue of road safety is a type of “elite capture”, in which the use of public infrastructure by wealthier people is privileged over the needs of others. Pedestrians and cyclists (along with two-wheeler and public transport users) are more likely to be road accident victims than private car users. They are also likely to be poorer than private car users, and are forced to walk or cycle because they cannot afford any other option. These social divisions are exacerbated by the lack of safe roads. This absence worsens poorer peoples’ quality of life and prospects, constrains children’s access to school and playtime, and deprives adults of the health and well-being effects of walking in wealthier neighbourhoods.

It is in this context that the right to walk needs to be considered — not just as something to be expected as a part of how roads are built, but rather as a fundamental right guaranteed through the right to “move freely through the territory of India” and the “right to life” under Articles 19(1)(d) and 21 of the Constitution.

But what precisely is the legal import of the right to walk, and how can it have a real effect on the ground? By reading the right to walk into fundamental rights, the court has created a basis for its development. The case at hand had limited scope, but after settling the immediate legal issues, the court asked for it to be relisted as a writ petition. One can expect that the issue of walking will be considered in more specific terms in this subsequent iteration.

• SHRINKING SPACE

Pedestrian deaths in the country have more than doubled in 10 years.



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT & HIGHWAYS

Here’s a look at some of the directions in which the right to walk can be developed, considering its social and cultural ramifications as well as implementation challenges.

Walking is cultural and social, not just about infrastructure

The Supreme Court has pointed out that “walking is not just motion” but embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19(1)(a), Article 19(1)(b) and Article 19(1)(c).

To this, we can add the words of the iconic former mayor of Bogota, Enrique Peñalosa, who said: “Sidewalks are the relatives of parks and plazas, not of streets.” They are for conversations, socialising, doing business and children playing, as much as they are for individual autonomy and mobility.

The pedestrian “right of way” has to respond to the social and biophysical requirements of the human beings who use it. A pavement imagined as a sterile strip of infrastructure is not necessarily safe or comfortable for its users without shade-giving trees, places for rest, food and water, and “eyes on the street”. The last of these is a concept developed by the urban theorist Jane Jacobs, who observed that public spaces become safer when more people — residents, shopkeepers, pedestrians, cafe patrons — are around.

When viewed in isolation from its social setting, the right to walk could easily run into conflict with the livelihood rights of hawkers. This, however, is a self-defeating understanding of the ecosystem of walking, which includes cycling, walking, public transport, neighbourhood life and workday



Two-wheelers occupy a footpath on a Delhi bridge. PRAVEEN KHANNA/FILE

commutes. Moreover, to interpret a fundamental right in a way that denies the vulnerabilities and lived realities of people would defeat the purpose of the Constitution.

The right to walk should not come at the cost of making people poorer, or by closing off avenues of everyday commerce, rest and refreshment. Social interactions and the exchange of news and views are all part of the life of pavements.

The presence of vendors and shade-giving trees on the roadside might seem inconvenient from an engineering point of view, but they are necessary accompaniments of our street life. Ideally, they should coexist alongside the pedestrian right of way. This is not an impossible task if it is secured through administrative intervention at the street-level, by shifting vending spots a few paces here and there, working around the trees and planning spaces for rest and shade where they are not available.

The right to walk should not be limited to islands

Many of the social and cultural issues around walking are in fact taken into account in a clutch of recent design-led projects such as Chandni Chowk and Aurobindo Marg in Delhi, Church Street and Gandhi Bazaar in Bengaluru and CG Road in Ahmedabad. But while these interventions are well-intentioned, they tend to be small and intensive projects with limited geographical impact.

The Supreme Court’s intervention on this issue nudges us in a different direction, to think about how walking as a fundamental right can be made mainstream and local. For

this, it should be achievable within available budgets and resources. Perfect design-led solutions may have to be sacrificed for making conditions safer and more comfortable for pedestrians on every kind of street.

This is not to say that pedestrian life does not need aesthetic imagination, but that form should follow functionality. It is more critical that people get networks of circulation — from home to the bus, work, school, or the market — rather than small islands of perfectly constructed space. Interventions should prioritise the needs of vulnerable groups and focus on places where there are lots of walkers, such as in the areas around schools, bus stands and train stations, labour chowks and low-income neighbourhoods.

Institutional fragmentation around pedestrian rights

There is a legal and institutional vacuum around the issue of walkability. The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 imposes duties on motorists vis-à-vis pedestrians, but it is primarily a law for motor vehicles and cannot secure the public rights of pedestrians.

There are, separately, a number of engineering designs and standards of road safety that should be applied in road construction projects, but these are not legally enforceable and fall short of a right for pedestrians.

To end this vacuum, the Supreme Court has sought a standalone framework for pedestrians in which municipalities, development authorities and panchayats are responsible for ensuring the right to walk. It has called for a regulatory structure through which the right can be implemented.

In many states, the current relationship of municipalities to pavements is fragmented into a cluster of different tasks — tree pruning, sweeping, drainage, regulating hawkers — without responsibility for overall outcome. Municipalities also deal with pavements side-by-side with other agencies: development authorities and public works departments construct many of the city roads, and electricity departments and water boards plant their infrastructure all over it (often blocking the way for walkers). The traffic police are responsible for policing the movement of cars, and municipalities run demarcated parking areas, but sometimes neither considers themselves accountable for cars parked on the pavement.

It would be impractical to unify these diverse functions into one administrative agency. It could, however, be the task of the municipality to integrate and pull together the various pieces of the puzzle to ensure a safe and comfortable right of way for walkers.

• DIPLOMACY

From 5 Indians to 5% of population: Diaspora key to Seychelles ties

Divya A
New Delhi, June 26

IT WAS IN 1770 that five Indians landed in Seychelles as plantation workers, along with seven African slaves and 15 French colonists, recorded as the first inhabitants of the Islands located in the Indian Ocean. Today, persons of Indian origin comprise 5% of the island nation’s population.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi heads to Seychelles on a three-day visit beginning Saturday, here is a look at the ties that bind the two countries located 4,000 km apart.

Migration and trade

It was from the 20th century that a constant flow of Indians, mostly from Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and later Gujarat, came to reside in Seychelles as traders, labourers and construction workers.

In fact, during the British colonial period, Seychelles was governed from the Bombay Presidency for some time, with regular shipping and flow of goods from

India. These trade links facilitated the migration of an Indian trading community looking for greener pastures, having reached a saturation point in East Africa.

The number of Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs) with Seychelles citizenship is estimated at around 6,000 presently, which is significant in a country with a population of about 120,000. A majority belong to the Gujarati and the Tamil communities.

Diplomatic relations

When Seychelles attained freedom on June 29, 1976, a contingent from the Indian Naval Ship, INS Nilgiri, took part in the Independence Day celebrations. This year, as PM Modi is attending the 50th Independence Day celebrations as the Guest of Honour, an Indian Armed Forces contingent and two Indian Navy ships are participating as well.

Diplomatic ties were established with Seychelles in 1976. Earlier this year, Modi also described Seychelles as a key part of India’s maritime policy — Vision MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Se-

Global south strategy

● Seychelles is an important part of India’s Global South strategy, serving as a critical maritime partner in the Western Indian Ocean.

● The island nation also helps India combat seaborne terrorism, piracy, and illegal fishing.

● Situated close to Africa, the Middle East, and Asia, Seychelles serves as a vital counterweight against China’s expanding influence in the Indian Ocean.

curity and Growth Across Regions).

Cultural ties

With a significant Indian diaspora, cultural contacts have been primarily community-driven. In June 2022, a statue of Mahatma Gandhi was erected at the Peace Park in Victoria, which also had statues of Nelson Mandela, the first President of South Africa and Sir James Mancham, the founding President of Seychelles.

Today, the Indian-origin community is visible in all walks of life, but mostly dominating the trading and construction sectors. There are also over 9,000 NRIs holding Gainful Employment Permits, working in the construction sector, as shop assistants and as professionals.

In 2015, the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman Award was conferred on Justice D Karunakaran of the Supreme Court of Seychelles, becoming the second recipient from the country after V Ramadoss (2006), an entrepreneur and medical advisor to the Seychelles President.

PM’s visit

PM Modi had earlier visited Seychelles in 2015, while the first Indian PM to visit Seychelles was Indira Gandhi in 1981. During his three-day visit, Modi will address the National Assembly of Seychelles and interact with members of the Indian community. Beyond cultural relations, India has emerged as one of Seychelles’ most trusted development partners through grants, concessional credit and capacity-building initiatives. More than 1% of Seychelles’ population has received professional training in India.

Over the years, New Delhi has extended significant Lines of Credit and grant assistance supporting infrastructure, healthcare, education and public transport.

This year, Modi also announced a Special Economic Package of \$175 million for Seychelles. India also continues to be a premier medical tourism destination for Seychelles, with institutional tie-ups connecting island hospitals with facilities in cities like Chennai.

• GLOBAL

‘Genocidal intent’: The implications of a UN panel report for cases against Israel

Madhurita Goswami
New Delhi, June 26

IN A report released this week, a United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) commission of inquiry said that Israel has deliberately targeted Palestinian children in Gaza, documenting a pattern of acts to establish genocidal intent.

The commission called children “not just part of a population” but whose survival was “central to the existence and continuity” of the Palestinians. “The sheer number of cases investigated and documented by the commission showing a clear pattern that children were directly targeted by the Israeli security forces constitutes a key element in the Israeli authorities’ genocidal intent to destroy the Palestinian group in Gaza,” it said.

The commission

The report has been released by the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem and Israel. The commission was established in May

2021 through a UNHRC resolution as an independent body to follow up on the conditions in the occupied Palestinian territory. It is mandated to submit annual reports.

The commission is currently chaired by S Muralidhar of India, who retired in 2023 as the Chief Justice of the Odisha High Court. Other members are Florence Mumba of Zambia and Chris Sidoti of Australia.

Israel’s actions

The commission cited instances to describe what it called “the intentional killing of Palestinian children through airstrikes in populated areas”. As part of the inquiry, it interviewed medical practitioners who reported a consistent pattern of children with single gunshot wounds inflicted by quadcopters or snipers, and reviewed photos, videos, CT scans and X-rays provided by them.

The report highlighted that the October 2025 ceasefire between Israel and the Palestinian militant group Hamas did not stop the violence. There have been increasing killings of Palestinians, including children, near the “yellow line” — an Israel-declared



Mourners at the funeral of an Israeli airstrike victim in Gaza City. AP

security buffer zone that cuts north-to-south through the Gaza Strip. The line, originally established as part of the US-mediated October 2025 Gaza peace plan, marks the specific boundary to which the Israeli military withdrew while maintaining control over a

significant portion of the Strip.

The report also discussed the torture of children during arrests and detention, including “rape, threats of rape, sexual assault, violence to the genitals, forcible stripping and humiliating acts”. It also alleged that Israeli forces intentionally targeted schools and orphanages, forced the closure of paediatric hospitals, and destroyed infrastructure necessary for children’s survival. The commission urged Israel to halt operations in Gaza, return the bodies of killed children and adjudicate incidents involving children in special courts, among other things. Israel has called the report a “libellous sham” and “defamatory”.

In September 2025, the commission, then chaired by Navi Pillay of South Africa and comprising Miloon Kothari of India and Chris Sidoti of Australia, had reached similar conclusions on genocidal intent.

Defining genocide

The UN Genocide Convention, under Article II, defines genocide as “any of the following acts committed with intent to de-

stroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial or religious group, as such:

1. Killing members of the group;
2. Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group;
3. Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part;
4. Imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group;
5. Forcibly transferring children of the group to another group.”

While a UN commission does not have the power to impose legal penalties, its findings can be used by international courts as documentary evidence. Noah Weisbord, associate professor of law at McGill University in Montreal, Canada, told *The Indian Express* that the report adds to the growing body of evidence of “genocidal intent” in cases against Israel.

For instance, in South Africa’s genocide case against Israel before the International Court of Justice, the court has said that Palestinians in Gaza have plausible rights under the UN Genocide Convention that

require protection. Weisbord said this points to plausible violation, but the evidence required to prove genocide is held to a much higher standard.

“Ethnic cleansing, indiscriminate killing, or war crimes alone are not sufficient to establish it,” he said. According to him, testimony from commission members, along with photographic and documentary evidence and individual witness statements, would play the deciding role.

Raushan Tara Jaswal, assistant professor of law at O P Jindal Global University, said that it is hard to establish the mental element of genocidal intent. She told *The Indian Express* that unlike in the case of the Rohingya in Myanmar where an ethnicity was targeted, Palestinians do not squarely fit into such definitions of identity.

Weisbord said there was more hope for the one against Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in the International Criminal Court “as more details emerge about the chain of command behind acts of genocide, identifying specific battalions and government leaders’ involvement”.